CALIFORNIA STATE UNIVERSITY, FULLERTON

MASTER OF PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION

STUDENT HANDBOOK

2026–2027

Division of Politics, Administration & Justice
College of Humanities and Social Sciences

CSUF
Public Administration
Division of Politics, Administration, and Justice
COLLEGE OF HUMANITIES AND SOCIAL SCIENCES

ACADEMIC YEAR

2026–2027

Revised November 7, 2026

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1. Introduction

Welcome to the Master of Public Administration (MPA) program at California State University, Fullerton (CSUF). This handbook explains the program's requirements, policies, milestones, and student resources.

Please note: This handbook is a guide for students. The CSUF University Catalog, University Policy Statements, and official university web pages are the authoritative sources for program requirements, policies, and procedures. If this handbook differs from an official university publication, the official publication governs.

Acknowledgment of Effort

The CSUF MPA Student Handbook was originally developed by Dr. Samuel B. Stone, who served as its primary author and editor from 2015 to 2023. His work gave MPA students a structured and accessible guide to the program.

The handbook is currently maintained by Dr. David P. Adams, who continues to update and refine the content to ensure that it remains relevant and useful for current and future MPA students.

2. Mission, Vision, and Values

Mission

We prepare leaders to address complex social issues, uphold democratic values, and foster a commitment to ethical, equitable, and inclusive public service in Orange County and beyond.

Vision

Our vision is to be a program recognized for excellence in value-driven public service and community engagement.

Program Values

Our program values reflect the core commitments of public administration. They guide our teaching, scholarship, and community engagement, and shape the professional identity we foster in future public service leaders.

- **Accountability**: Promoting transparency, responsiveness, and evidence-informed decisions that uphold public trust and integrity.
- **Ethics**: Advancing integrity, fairness, and service to the public good by fostering ethical reasoning and critical awareness in public administration.
- **Collaboration**: Building skills for cross-sector partnerships, networked governance, and inclusive stakeholder engagement.
- **Lifelong Learning**: Instilling habits of continuous learning, reflective practice, and professional development to support adaptive leaders and long-term impact.

3. NASPAA Accreditation

The MPA program is accredited by the Network of Schools of Public Policy, Affairs and Administration (NASPAA). The curriculum is designed to develop the following competencies:

- Lead and manage in public governance
- Participate in and contribute to the policy process
- Analyze, synthesize, think critically, solve problems and make decisions
- Articulate and apply a public service perspective
- Communicate and interact productively with a diverse and changing workforce and citizenry

The program has been accredited since 1989 and was most recently reaccredited by NASPAA in 2025. To learn more, visit the NASPAA website.

4. General Facts

CSUF has offered the MPA program since 1968, making it Orange County's original public MPA program. The program typically enrolls about 100 students and graduates approximately 30 students each year. Alumni work in local governments, county agencies, and nonprofit organizations, particularly in Orange and Los Angeles counties.

Curriculum and Format

The curriculum emphasizes ethical and evidence-based decision-making and prepares students for management and leadership roles in the public sector. Because most students are working professionals, courses are offered in the evening from 7:00 to 9:45 PM, Monday through Thursday, in face-to-face, synchronous online, and hybrid formats. Students typically take one or two courses per semester. International students must enroll in at least 9 units during the fall and spring semesters to maintain full-time status.

Student Profile

Most students are working professionals with at least three years of experience in public agencies. Many enroll because their supervisors recommend the MPA as a step toward leadership. Others already hold supervisory or managerial roles and seek to build on their expertise. A smaller number of pre-service students enroll to gain foundational knowledge before entering the field.

Program Structure

The program does not currently offer a dual-degree option. It is supported by full-time faculty whose credentials are listed at the end of this handbook. The MPA program is housed in the Division of Politics, Administration & Justice (Gordon Hall 511), part of the College of Humanities and Social Sciences.

5. Admissions

The MPA program normally admits students for both fall and spring. Application dates can change from year to year. For spring 2027, the application deadline is November 15, 2026; fall deadlines are typically in early May. Applicants should confirm the current deadline on the MPA Admissions website before applying.

Admissions Process

Applicants apply online through Cal State Apply.

The Cal State Apply application requires:

- Unofficial transcripts from every college and university attended
- A statement of purpose
- A current résumé
- Two academic or professional letters of recommendation; when possible, applicants should select writers who can address their readiness for graduate study and public service

After applying, applicants should review the Tasks list in the CSUF Portal. Graduate applicants are normally required to have an official transcript sent directly to CSUF from the institution that awarded their bachelor's degree; Admissions may request transcripts from additional institutions. Recent CSUF graduates should consult Admissions to determine whether a new CSUF transcript is needed. Follow the university's current official transcript instructions.

- **Electronic submission (preferred):** Use an approved transcript service and follow the university's transcript instructions
- **Mail:** California State University, Fullerton, Office of Admissions, P.O. Box 6900, Fullerton, CA 92834-6900
- **Graduate Admissions questions:** gradadmissions@fullerton.edu
- **MPA admissions questions:** mpaadmissions@fullerton.edu

6. Admissions Criteria

To be considered for admission to the MPA program, applicants must have a minimum undergraduate GPA of 2.75. The average GPA of admitted students is approximately 3.3. Because the program receives more applications than it can accommodate, admission is competitive.

Experience in the public or nonprofit sector strengthens an application. The statement of purpose allows applicants to demonstrate graduate-level writing and explain their preparation and goals. The program reviews applications holistically, considering academic performance, professional experience, the written statement, and letters of recommendation. All required materials must be submitted regardless of an applicant's GPA.

GRE scores are not required. The program welcomes applicants from diverse academic and professional backgrounds who are committed to advancing in public service.

7. Cost of Degree

The MPA program is designed to be completed in three years when students take two courses in each fall and spring semester. Tuition depends on the number of units taken in a semester, and campus fees and other educational or living expenses add to the total cost of attendance. All figures below are 2026–2027 estimates and are subject to change.

Tuition and Mandatory Campus Fees

CSUF Graduate Studies publishes the following estimated tuition and mandatory campus fees per semester:

- **0–6 units:** $3,320.58 per semester
- **7 or more units:** $5,114.58 per semester

Nonresident students pay an additional $471 per unit of enrollment. These published estimates may differ slightly from the annual cost-of-attendance figures used for financial aid. The amount shown on the student's account is the amount due. For current charges, consult Student Business Services.

2026–2027 Standard Nine-Month Student Budget

Cost of attendance is a planning estimate used to determine financial aid eligibility. It includes estimated tuition and campus fees as well as typical expenses for books, housing, food, transportation, loan fees, and personal needs. Actual expenses will vary.

Full-Time Student Budget (7 or More Units per Semester)

Table 1: Estimated 2026–2027 full-time graduate student budget by housing situation

Expense Category	Commuter	On-Campus	Off-Campus
Mandatory Tuition	$8,548	$8,548	$8,548
Campus Fees	$1,678	$1,678	$1,678
Books & Supplies	$1,078	$1,078	$1,078
Housing	$0	$14,890	$13,625
Food	$11,162	$6,640	$7,431
Miscellaneous	$3,094	$3,274	$3,926
Transportation	$2,846	$1,678	$2,906
Loan Fee	$160	$160	$160
Total	**$28,566**	**$37,946**	**$39,352**

Part-Time Student Budget (0–6 Units per Semester)

Table 2: Estimated 2026–2027 part-time graduate student budget by housing situation

Expense Category	Commuter	On-Campus	Off-Campus
Mandatory Tuition	$4,960	$4,960	$4,960
Campus Fees	$1,678	$1,678	$1,678
Books & Supplies	$1,078	$1,078	$1,078
Housing	$0	$14,890	$13,625
Food	$11,162	$6,640	$7,431
Miscellaneous	$3,094	$3,274	$3,926
Transportation	$2,846	$1,678	$2,906
Loan Fee	$160	$160	$160
Total	**$24,978**	**$34,358**	**$35,764**

Key Considerations

- **Mandatory Tuition** refers to the state tuition fee based on enrollment status (part-time or full-time).
- **Campus Fees** are institutional charges assessed to all enrolled students.
- **Books & Supplies** account for necessary educational materials.
- **Housing** and **Food** expenses vary significantly based on living arrangements.
- **Miscellaneous** includes other personal and extracurricular expenses.
- **Transportation** costs depend on commuting needs and distances.
- **Loan Fee** represents charges associated with processing educational loans.

Additional Cost Information

- The Graduate Cost of Attendance page provides the official figures used to determine financial aid eligibility.
- Student Business Services publishes the current breakdown of tuition and campus fees.

Financial Aid Availability

- The Office of Financial Aid provides current information about aid eligibility, applications, and deadlines.
- Eligible graduate students may submit the Free Application for Federal Student Aid (FAFSA). See the graduate financial aid page for details.
- The Division of Politics, Administration & Justice periodically offers graduate assistantships. Contact the MPA Director for information about current opportunities.

8. Structure of the Program

General

The MPA degree requires 36 units, normally completed as 12 three-unit courses. Students must earn at least a 3.0 GPA in both their Study Plan and applicable graduate coursework, earn at least a C in every Study Plan course, and pass the comprehensive examination in POSC 521.

Degree at a Glance

- Complete the six required public administration core courses.
- Complete at least one breadth course: POSC 519, POSC 525, or POSC 528.
- Select one concentration and complete its requirements.
- Complete enough advisor-approved electives to bring the Study Plan to 36 units.
- Complete POSC 497 if the MPA Director or MPA Advisor determines that the internship requirement applies.
- Take POSC 521 and the comprehensive examination in the final semester, after completing all other MPA core courses.

Some courses appear in both the public administration core and a concentration. A course may satisfy more than one categorical requirement, but its three units count only once toward the 36-unit degree. The number of advisor-approved electives therefore varies by concentration, course selection, transfer credit, and any internship requirement. Students typically reach out to the Graduate Advisor to inquire whether the internship requirement applies. The approved Study Plan and Titan Degree Audit (TDA) show the exact courses each student must complete.

Core Courses

Students are required to take courses in:

- Introduction to Public Administration
- Organizational theory
- Research methods
- Public finance
- Human resources management
- Local government management, state and local government, or public policy
- A capstone course in public administration theory

Concentrations

The program offers concentrations in Human Resources Management, Local Government Management, Public Finance Management, and Public Policy. Every student must select exactly one concentration. The MPA degree requires 36 units regardless of the concentration selected.

9. Degree Requirements

Prerequisites

Students admitted to the program must have completed courses in three areas:

1. **American Government or U.S. History:** Must be completed before beginning MPA coursework.
2. **Statistics or Research Methods:** must be completed by the end of the second semester in the program. Any course in statistics or quantitative research methods is sufficient.
3. **Macro- or Microeconomics:** must be completed by the end of the second semester in the program. Any course in economics is sufficient.

Prerequisites may be completed at any undergraduate level at an accredited college or university, including a community college. Students must earn a C or better. Prerequisites do not count toward the graduate degree or graduate GPA.

The admission notice identifies any outstanding prerequisites. Students who complete a prerequisite after admission must submit a transcript documenting completion to the MPA Advisor before the concentration can be added to the Study Plan.

Public Administration Core

Students must take all of the following courses:

- **POSC 509** Foundations of Public Administration
- **POSC 521** Capstone Seminar: Public Administration Theory
- **POSC 523** Administrative Research and Analysis
- **POSC 526** Public Organizational Theory & Behavior
- **POSC 571** Public Budgeting and Finance
- **POSC 572** Human Resource Management for Public Organizations

And at least one of the following:

- **POSC 519** State and Local Government
- **POSC 525** Local Government Management
- **POSC 528** Seminar in Public Policy

All core courses must be completed before students take the comprehensive examination.

10. Internship

Students without sufficient recent administrative or managerial experience in the public or nonprofit sector must complete:

- **POSC 497** Internship in Public Administration

The MPA Director or MPA Advisor determines whether the internship requirement applies after reviewing the student's professional background. Because the relevance and recency of experience vary by position, students should obtain this determination early in the program and ensure that it is reflected on the Study Plan. When required, POSC 497 is included in the 36-unit Study Plan; the MPA Director or MPA Advisor will identify how it applies to the student's remaining requirements.

POSC 497 is a three-unit course with written assignments and 300 hours of supervised experience in a public or nonprofit organization. Consistent with the program's mission, many students intern in local government. The program maintains placement leads developed through longstanding relationships with agencies and alumni.

Students may also complete an approved internship in Washington, D.C., through the Cal State DC program. Students interested in this option should consult the MPA Director before applying.

Historically, approximately one-third of CSUF MPA internships have been paid. Compensation and placement availability vary, and students are responsible for securing an approved position with assistance from the program.

To help offset the financial burden of an unpaid internship, Bruce Lawson (CSUF MPA 1972) has supported the Lawson Internship in Public Service Award since 2010. The award provides a $2,000 scholarship to at least one POSC 497 student each semester through a competitive application reviewed by program faculty.

11. Program Concentrations

There are currently four concentrations within the program. All students must choose one. They are:

- **Human Resources Management**
- **Local Government Management**
- **Public Finance Management**
- **Public Policy**

Students normally select a concentration during the second semester, after completing approximately 12 MPA units. Students are encouraged to choose a concentration that complements their experience, skills, and professional goals.

How overlapping requirements work: Some concentration courses also appear in the public administration core or in more than one concentration category. A course can satisfy each applicable category, but its units count only once toward the degree. Advisor-approved electives fill the remaining space needed to reach 36 units. The MPA Advisor or MPA Director will confirm the exact number of electives on the student's Study Plan.

Concentration in Human Resources Management

Core Course

- **POSC 572** Human Resource Management for Public Organizations

Concentration Electives (Take Any Two)

- **MGMT 441** Labor–Management Relations
- **POSC 423** Diversity in Public Management
- **POSC 475** Administrative Law
- **POSC 522** Seminar in Public Personnel Administration
- **POSC 582** Organizational Development and Change

Advisor-Approved Electives

Take the number of advisor-approved electives needed to complete the 36-unit Study Plan:

- **CRJU 491** Applied Policy Research
- **MGMT 441** Labor–Management Relations
- **POSC 421** Government and the Economy
- **POSC 423** Diversity in Public Management

- **POSC 424** Health Policy
- **POSC 425** Policy Analysis
- **POSC 426** Education Politics and Policy
- **POSC 427** Metropolitan Politics and Policymaking
- **POSC 430** Nonprofit Organizations and Advocacy
- **POSC 446** Corruption, Ethics and Public Policy
- **POSC 459** Social Welfare Politics and Policy
- **POSC 475** Administrative Law
- **POSC 478** Urban Planning Principles
- **POSC 484** Urban Planning Methods
- **POSC 491** Applied Policy Research
- **POSC 519** State and Local Government
- **POSC 522** Seminar in Public Personnel Administration
- **POSC 525** Local Government Management
- **POSC 528** Seminar in Public Policy
- **POSC 580** Emergency Management in Public Administration
- **POSC 582** Organizational Development and Change
- **POSC 583** Public Budgeting and Finance II
- **POSC 588** Collaborative Governance
- **PUBH 424** Health Policy

Concentration in Local Government Management

Core Course

- **POSC 525** Local Government Management

Concentration Core Courses (Take One)

- **POSC 427** Metropolitan Politics and Policymaking
- **POSC 519** State and Local Government

Concentration Electives (Take One)

- **POSC/GEOG 478** Urban Planning Principles
- **POSC/GEOG 484** Urban Planning Methods
- **POSC 427** Metropolitan Politics and Policymaking
- **POSC 519** State and Local Government
- **POSC 580** Emergency Management in Public Administration
- **POSC 588** Collaborative Governance
- **ENST 595T** Selected Topics in Environmental Problems (only approved sections count; consult the MPA Advisor before enrolling)

Advisor-Approved Electives

Take the number of advisor-approved electives needed to complete the 36-unit Study Plan:

- **CRJU 491** Applied Policy Research
- **MGMT 441** Labor–Management Relations
- **POSC 421** Government and the Economy
- **POSC 423** Diversity in Public Management
- **POSC 424** Health Policy
- **POSC 425** Policy Analysis
- **POSC 426** Education Politics and Policy
- **POSC 427** Metropolitan Politics and Policymaking

- **POSC 430** Nonprofit Organizations and Advocacy
- **POSC 446** Corruption, Ethics and Public Policy
- **POSC 459** Social Welfare Politics and Policy
- **POSC 475** Administrative Law
- **POSC 478** Urban Planning Principles
- **POSC 484** Urban Planning Methods
- **POSC 491** Applied Policy Research
- **POSC 519** State and Local Government
- **POSC 522** Seminar in Public Personnel Administration
- **POSC 528** Seminar in Public Policy
- **POSC 580** Emergency Management in Public Administration
- **POSC 582** Organizational Development and Change
- **POSC 583** Public Budgeting and Finance II
- **POSC 588** Collaborative Governance
- **PUBH 424** Health Policy

Concentration in Public Finance Management

Concentration Core Courses (Take Both)

- **POSC 571** Public Budgeting and Finance
- **POSC 583** Public Budgeting and Finance II

Concentration Electives (Take One)

- **POSC 421** Government and the Economy
- **POSC 425** Policy Analysis
- **ECON 416** Benefit Cost and Microeconomic Policy Analysis
- **ECON 417** Public Finance

Advisor-Approved Electives

Take the number of advisor-approved electives needed to complete the 36-unit Study Plan:

- **CRJU 491** Applied Policy Research
- **ECON 416** Benefit Cost and Microeconomic Policy Analysis
- **ECON 417** Public Finance
- **POSC 421** Government and the Economy
- **POSC 423** Diversity in Public Management
- **POSC 424** Health Policy
- **POSC 425** Policy Analysis
- **POSC 426** Education Politics and Policy
- **POSC 427** Metropolitan Politics and Policymaking
- **POSC 430** Nonprofit Organizations and Advocacy
- **POSC 446** Corruption, Ethics and Public Policy
- **POSC 459** Social Welfare Politics and Policy
- **POSC 475** Administrative Law
- **POSC 478** Urban Planning Principles
- **POSC 484** Urban Planning Methods

- **POSC 491** Applied Policy Research
- **POSC 519** State and Local Government
- **POSC 522** Seminar in Public Personnel Administration
- **POSC 525** Local Government Management
- **POSC 528** Seminar in Public Policy
- **POSC 580** Emergency Management in Public Administration
- **POSC 582** Organizational Development and Change
- **POSC 588** Collaborative Governance
- **PUBH 424** Health Policy

Concentration in Public Policy

Concentration Core Courses (Take Both)

- **POSC 425** Policy Analysis
- **POSC 528** Seminar in Public Policy

Concentration Electives (Take One)

- **POSC 421** Government and the Economy
- **POSC 426** Education Politics and Policy
- **POSC 427** Metropolitan Politics and Policymaking
- **POSC 428** Environmental Politics and Policy
- **POSC 430** Nonprofit Organizations and Advocacy
- **CRJU 405** Criminal Justice Policy
- **CRJU/POSC 491** Applied Policy Research
- **ECON 416** Benefit Cost and Microeconomic Policy Analysis
- **PUBH 524** Public Health Administration

Advisor-Approved Electives

Take the number of advisor-approved electives needed to complete the 36-unit Study Plan:

- **CRJU 405** Criminal Justice Policy
- **CRJU 491** Applied Policy Research
- **ECON 416** Benefit Cost and Microeconomic Policy Analysis
- **POSC 421** Government and the Economy
- **POSC 423** Diversity in Public Management
- **POSC 424** Health Policy
- **POSC 426** Education Politics and Policy
- **POSC 427** Metropolitan Politics and Policymaking
- **POSC 446** Corruption, Ethics and Public Policy
- **POSC 475** Administrative Law
- **POSC 478** Urban Planning Principles
- **POSC 484** Urban Planning Methods
- **POSC 491** Applied Policy Research
- **POSC 519** State and Local Government
- **POSC 525** Local Government Management
- **POSC 580** Emergency Management in Public Administration
- **POSC 582** Organizational Development and Change
- **POSC 583** Public Budgeting and Finance II
- **POSC 588** Collaborative Governance
- **PUBH 424** Health Policy
- **PUBH 524** Public Health Administration

12. Comprehensive Examination

Key Information

- The comprehensive examination is a graduation requirement that assesses mastery of core public administration concepts.
- Students answer one general public administration question and demonstrate their ability to synthesize and apply knowledge from across the MPA curriculum.
- Students should begin preparing early and retain notes and course materials from all core courses.

Overview

- The comprehensive examination is integrated into **POSC 521: Capstone Seminar in Public Administration Theory**, which serves as the culminating experience of the MPA program.
- The examination evaluates a student's ability to:
  - Understand and apply core public administration theories and frameworks
  - Analyze and synthesize public administration literature
  - Apply theoretical concepts to real-world scenarios
  - Integrate knowledge from across the MPA curriculum

Eligibility Requirements

- To take **POSC 521** and the comprehensive examination, students must have successfully completed all **core MPA courses**.
- Enrollment in **POSC 521** is by permit only. Students must meet with the MPA Advisor before enrolling.
- The capstone course should be taken in the final semester after fulfilling all other core requirements.

Examination Format

- **Take-home examination** with one week to complete
- **One general public administration question**
- **Blind grading process** to ensure fairness

Grading Criteria

- Faculty readers evaluate responses independently through a blind-grading process.
- Students receive one of the following outcomes:
  - **High Pass**, **Pass**, **Low Pass**, or **Fail**
  - High Pass, Pass, and Low Pass are passing outcomes.
  - A failing outcome is assigned when at least two readers determine that the response does not meet the required standards.

Retake Policy

- A student who fails the examination has **one opportunity** to retake it.
- The retake occurs within the same semester, shortly after results are released.
  - A student who does not pass the retake is subject to disqualification from the program.
  - At their discretion, the MPA faculty may first offer the student an oral examination as a final opportunity.
  - Failure to pass an offered oral examination results in disqualification from the MPA program.

Additional Details

- Comprehensive examination guidelines, including format and evaluation criteria, will be provided during **POSC 521**.

- Students are encouraged to engage with faculty and peers throughout the course to refine their understanding of core concepts.

Students with Disabilities

- Students seeking examination accommodations should register with Disability Support Services (DSS) and follow the DSS accommodation process before the examination.

13. Advising

During the fall and spring semesters, the **MPA Advisor** provides primary academic advising. Assistance includes:

- Academic program planning
- Selecting a concentration
- Evaluating transfer credits
- Choosing electives
- Understanding administrative procedures

The **MPA Director** can perform the same advising functions. The MPA Director provides most advising during winter and summer terms, when the MPA Advisor is normally off contract, and is also available for program-level questions throughout the year. Other faculty members are available for individual mentorship.

Advising schedules are announced each semester. Students may contact the MPA Advisor directly by email or use the program's MPA advising email address for questions or appointments. The Division Office can be reached at 657-278-3521, Monday–Friday, 8:00 a.m.–5:00 p.m.

Students are responsible for scheduling their advising appointments and staying informed about program requirements. Advising is required at least twice:

1. **During the second semester or after approximately 12 units**—to declare a concentration and confirm the Study Plan.
2. **Before the final semester**—to review the TDA and prepare for graduation.

POSC 521 is permit-only. Students must meet with the MPA Advisor before enrolling in it.

Students should retain copies of transcripts, grades, approved petitions, advising correspondence, and Study Plan changes.

Titan Degree Audit (TDA)

The **Titan Degree Audit (TDA)** is an official tool used to track academic progress. It helps students:

- Monitor how completed coursework applies to degree and concentration requirements.
- Ensure they are meeting graduation requirements.
- Plan their remaining coursework effectively.

The TDA is available through the CSUF Student Portal. Instructions are available in the Titan Degree Audit tutorial.

Initial Study Plan

Upon admission, every MPA student is placed on an initial Study Plan that includes the following core courses:

- **POSC 509** - Foundations of Public Administration
- **POSC 523** - Administrative Research and Analysis
- **POSC 526** - Public Organizational Theory & Behavior
- **POSC 571** - Public Budgeting and Finance
- **POSC 572** - Human Resource Management for Public Organizations

The initial TDA displays these courses until the student meets with the MPA Advisor or MPA Director and formally selects a **concentration**. Once the concentration is recorded, the remaining degree requirements appear on the TDA.

14. Milestones toward Completion of the Degree

First Semester

Enroll in **POSC 509: Foundations of Public Administration** and up to **one** of the following core courses:

- **POSC 523** - Administrative Research and Analysis
- **POSC 526** - Public Organizational Theory & Behavior
- **POSC 571** - Public Budgeting and Finance
- **POSC 572** - Human Resource Management for Public Organizations

Second Semester

- Complete any outstanding statistics or research methods and economics prerequisites by the end of the semester.
- Meet with the MPA Advisor or MPA Director to select a **concentration**, confirm whether POSC 497 is required, and review the Study Plan.
- Enroll in up to **two** of the following core courses:
  - **POSC 523** - Administrative Research and Analysis
  - **POSC 526** - Public Organizational Theory & Behavior
  - **POSC 571** - Public Budgeting and Finance
  - **POSC 572** - Human Resource Management for Public Organizations

After Completing 18 Units

- Review the TDA and remaining course rotation with the MPA Advisor or MPA Director.
- Students with a **GPA of 3.70 or higher** are eligible to join **Pi Alpha Alpha**, the national honor society for public administration.

Before the Final Semester

- Confirm that all core courses will be completed before POSC 521.
- Meet with the MPA Advisor before enrolling in POSC 521, which is permit-only.
- Apply for a graduation check by the published deadline.
- Resolve any TDA discrepancies with the MPA Advisor or MPA Director.

Final Semester

- Enroll in **POSC 521: Capstone Seminar in Public Administration Theory** (by permit).
- Take the **comprehensive examination** during the course.

15. CSUF Graduate Academic Standards

This section summarizes the provisions of UPS 410.106, Academic Standards for Graduate Degree Students, effective June 16, 2026, that are most relevant to MPA students. The official policy and University Catalog govern if this summary differs from them.

MPA and University Requirements

University policy requires at least 30 approved units for a master's degree; the CSUF MPA requires **36 units**. The following rules apply to the MPA Study Plan:

- At least 21 units must be completed in residence as part of the CSUF degree program. Transfer courses and courses taken through CSUF Extension are not in-residence units.
- Study Plan courses must be at the 400, 500, or equivalent level. A 400-level course must be approved for graduate credit; a 400-level General Education course cannot count.
- Admission prerequisites cannot count toward the Study Plan.
- At least 24 units must carry letter grades.
- No course applied to another degree may be included on the Study Plan.
- No more than six units of independent study may be included.
- Any Study Plan change outside the approved curriculum requires the approval of the MPA Advisor or MPA Director and the appropriate Provost designee.

The MPA's additional limit is explained in the later section on 400-level courses.

Time Limit

Students must complete all Study Plan courses within five years. This period covers 10 consecutive semesters and begins with the earliest course on the Study Plan. A student may petition to extend the limit to seven years (14 consecutive semesters).

With the required approvals, no more than nine units of outdated coursework may be validated. Coursework more than 10 years old and outdated transfer coursework cannot be validated. Students approaching the five-year limit should contact the MPA Advisor or MPA Director before the limit expires.

Continuous Enrollment

Students must remain enrolled in every fall and spring semester from admission until the degree is awarded. A student who is not taking a regular course may maintain enrollment through an approved leave of absence or, when eligible, GRAD 700:

- GRAD 700 is available only after the student has enrolled in all Study Plan coursework, has advisor approval, and is still completing the culminating experience.
- International students also need approval from International Student Services to enroll in GRAD 700.
- A student who does not maintain continuous enrollment must reapply to the university and meet the admission standards in effect for the semester of readmission.

Advancement to Candidacy

Students must advance to candidacy before degree conferral. A student is eligible after attaining classified standing and completing at least nine Study Plan units. The MPA Advisor or MPA Director reviews and approves the Study Plan used for degree conferral.

MPA Culminating Experience

University policy permits each master's program to designate an appropriate culminating experience. For the MPA, the required culminating experience is the comprehensive examination administered in **POSC 521: Capstone Seminar in Public Administration Theory**. The MPA does not offer a thesis or project in place of this examination.

Classified and Conditionally Classified Standing

Most MPA students are admitted in classified standing, which indicates that no additional preparatory conditions remain. An applicant who needs specific preparation for graduate study may be admitted in conditionally classified standing. The admission notice must identify the required courses, grades, and completion period. These conditions should be completed within two fall or spring semesters.

At the end of that period, the MPA Advisor or MPA Director reviews the student's progress and recommends either classified standing or discontinuation if the conditions have not been met. An applicant may appeal an admission decision within 15 days; no more than one admission appeal may be submitted per semester.

GPA and Repeated Courses

Students must maintain at least a 3.0 GPA in both:

- All graduate-level units attempted after admission to the degree program
- All Study Plan coursework

Every Study Plan course must be completed with a C (2.0) or better. If a course must be repeated, it may be repeated only once; both grades remain in the GPA calculation, and the repeated course provides no additional unit credit.

With prior approval, a student may request to add or repeat up to six units to raise the Study Plan GPA to 3.0. Any substitution for a course with an unsatisfactory grade requires approval from the MPA Advisor or MPA Director and the appropriate Provost designee.

Academic Notice and Disqualification

A student is placed on academic notice if either the applicable graduate GPA or Study Plan GPA falls below 3.0. Academic notice may also result from repeated withdrawals, failure to make progress, noncompliance with an academic requirement, failure to meet the profession's standards of competence or fitness, or conduct addressed by applicable university policy.

A master's student on academic notice must raise both GPAs to at least 3.0 by the end of the second regular semester following the term in which a GPA first fell below 3.0. A student may be disqualified if the GPAs are not raised within that period or cannot mathematically be raised within it. Disqualification removes the student from the program and from graduate standing.

If the MPA program has no separate appeal policy, the Graduate Disqualification Appeals Committee reviews an appeal. A student disqualified from a master's program may apply for readmission to the same program after one calendar year. Readmission requires a new Study Plan that meets current requirements; use of prior coursework requires university approval.

Prior and Transfer Coursework

With the required approvals, a master's student may petition to apply up to nine units of 400- or 500-level coursework completed while an undergraduate at CSUF if the coursework:

- Was not used for any requirement of the bachelor's degree
- Falls within the student's five-year degree-completion period
- Was completed with a B or better

Transfer coursework must have been completed with a B or better at a regionally accredited institution or equivalent, be acceptable toward the same graduate degree at that institution, fall within the CSUF five-year degree period, and not have been applied to another degree. Transfer or prior coursework does not apply automatically; students must request evaluation by the MPA Advisor or MPA Director.

16. Leaves of Absence

MPA students must maintain continuous enrollment in fall and spring until the degree is awarded. A student who needs to interrupt enrollment should consult the MPA Advisor or MPA Director and request a leave rather than simply not enrolling.

Eligibility and Procedure

After completing at least one semester in residence, a conditionally classified or classified graduate student may request a leave of absence for up to two consecutive semesters. The request must be submitted before the first day of classes for the affected term. Current forms and instructions are available from Graduate Studies.

A leave may be requested for circumstances such as:

- Illness, disability, pregnancy, or another serious personal circumstance
- Professional development that supports the student's career objectives

- Active military service
- Severe financial hardship
- Another documented reason approved by the university

Requests are reviewed by the appropriate university officials and may require supporting documentation.

Effect of a Leave or Break in Enrollment

An approved leave preserves the student's place in the university and MPA program and preserves applicable catalog rights. A leave does **not** extend the time limit for completing the degree.

A student who takes an unapproved break in enrollment must reapply to CSUF and the MPA program and meet the requirements in effect at the time of readmission.

17. A Note on 400-Level Courses

Only 400-level courses approved for graduate credit may appear on a graduate Study Plan; the University Catalog identifies those courses. The MPA permits no more than three such courses, or nine units, to count toward the degree.

In a 400-level course approved for graduate credit, the instructor must assign graduate students additional readings and substantive graduate-level work. These requirements must appear in the syllabus and may not consist only of longer versions of undergraduate assignments. Graduate credit may be revoked if a course does not meet this requirement. Students should confirm at the beginning of the term that the instructor knows they are enrolled for graduate credit. POSC 497 Internship in Public Administration does not count toward this limit.

18. Completion of the Degree and Graduation

To earn the MPA, students must complete the approved 36-unit Study Plan, maintain at least a 3.0 GPA in both applicable graduate coursework and Study Plan coursework, earn

at least a C in every Study Plan course, and pass the comprehensive examination. All university and program requirements must be satisfied.

Deadlines

Except for scheduled final examinations, all degree work must be submitted by the last day of classes for the degree to be awarded at the end of that term. Degree conferral requires completion of all university requirements and all requirements on the approved Study Plan.

19. Applying for Graduation

Students must apply for a graduation check and pay the graduation and diploma fee by the published deadline.

The filing deadline is published in the Registration Guide and on the Graduate Studies website. The effective graduation date is the last day of the term in which all requirements are completed.

Students who do not complete the requirements in the term originally selected must request a change to the graduation date by the applicable deadline. An additional fee may apply.

Commencement

Commencement ceremonies are held at the end of the spring semester. Students become eligible to participate after filing for a graduation check and paying the required fee. Eligibility rules depend on the student's expected graduation term.

The College normally sends commencement information in the spring. Consult the CSUF Commencement website for current eligibility, schedules, and procedures. Caps, gowns, and hoods are available through Titan Shops.

20. Academic Integrity

Academic dishonesty includes cheating, unauthorized collaboration, plagiarism, fabrication or falsification, helping another person commit a violation, and attempting any of these acts. Cheating includes obtaining or attempting to obtain academic credit through dishonest, deceptive, fraudulent, or unauthorized means. Plagiarism includes presenting another person's words, ideas, data, or creative work as one's own without appropriate attribution.

An instructor who believes academic dishonesty has occurred must follow university procedures, which include discussing the matter with the student when circumstances permit and documenting the basis for the allegation. Academic penalties and separate student-conduct consequences may apply, subject to the student's appeal rights. The complete procedures appear in UPS 300.021, Academic Dishonesty.

The unauthorized use of generative AI or another technology may constitute academic dishonesty. Permitted uses vary by course and assignment, so students must follow the instructor's syllabus and assignment directions and ask before using a tool when the rules are unclear. Similarity-checking or other review tools may help an instructor evaluate work, but their output does not by itself establish that a violation occurred.

21. Student Conduct

The Student Conduct website explains the university's expectations for student behavior and the procedures used to address alleged violations.

22. Awards, Honors, and Scholarships

Irving Stone Prize

The Irving Stone Prize recognizes an outstanding essay written by an MPA student in a public administration course during the previous academic year. The recipient receives $100.

To enter, submit two copies of the essay with all identifying information removed to the Division of Politics, Administration & Justice by the deadline announced in the spring.

Attach a separate cover sheet containing:

1. Name
2. Student ID
3. Course, instructor, and semester in which the paper was written
4. Title of the paper

Sidney Baldwin Award

This certificate is presented annually to an outstanding MPA student in the graduating class. The MPA Director and program faculty consider the student's academic record, comprehensive examination performance, contributions to the MPA program, and other relevant accomplishments.

Spirit of Public Service Award

This certificate is presented annually to a graduating MPA student who has demonstrated a sustained commitment to public service and academic excellence. The MPA Director and program faculty consider the student's academic record, service, and other relevant activities.

Alan Saltzstein Excellence Scholarship

This $1,000 scholarship honors Dr. Alan Saltzstein, who led the MPA program for many years. It recognizes strong academic performance by students who have completed 6–12 MPA units and encourages continued excellence as they progress through the program.

The MPA Director distributes information about application procedures and deadlines during the fall and spring semesters.

Lawson Internship in Public Service

The Lawson Internship in Public Service provides $2,000 to at least one MPA student enrolled in POSC 497 each semester. The award helps offset income a student may forgo

while completing a public or nonprofit internship.

Applicants must:

1. Be enrolled in the MPA program
2. Be enrolled in POSC 497
3. Be interning in the public or nonprofit sector
4. Submit a letter describing:
   (a) Their progress in the MPA program
   (b) Their expectations for the internship and future plans
   (c) Circumstances that make the scholarship especially valuable to their public-service career

DC Internship

Since 2006, the Cal State DC program has offered students an opportunity to study and work in the nation's capital during the summer. Participants carry a full-time academic load while interning in Washington, D.C. MPA students may seek approved placements with executive agencies, advocacy groups, nonprofits, and other public-service organizations. Students should consult the MPA Director before applying to ensure that a proposed internship will satisfy their Study Plan.

Program costs vary. Major expenses include tuition, housing, food, local transportation, and travel to and from Washington, D.C. Tuition is the same as for comparable CSUF enrollment, but students should consult the program for current fees and estimated living expenses.

Visit the Cal State DC Scholars website for current information.

23. Campus Resources and Support

Career Center

(Langsdorf Hall 208)
Career Center website

Children's Center

Children's Center website

Diversity Initiatives and Resource Centers (DIRC)

DIRC builds inclusive communities, supports student belonging, and offers opportunities for engagement, reflection, and learning related to equity and social justice.
DIRC website

Student Wellness

Student Wellness connects students with Counseling and Psychological Services, Health Services, TitanWell, and related support.
Student Wellness website

Disability Support Services

Students seeking disability-related accommodations should register with Disability Support Services as early as possible.
Disability Support Services website

Graduate Studies

Graduate Studies maintains graduate forms and records, provides guidance on graduate policies, and offers academic support and workshops.

Graduate Studies website

Graduate Studies Center

(Pollak Library North (PLN) 121)
The Center provides graduate students with space to study and network and hosts workshops, graduate learning communities, and writing support.
Graduate Studies Center website

Parking and Transportation Services

Parking and Transportation Services website

Pollak Library

Pollak Library website

Titan Dreamers Resource Center

Titan Dreamers Resource Center website

Titan Shops

Titan Shops is the campus bookstore for textbooks, course materials, regalia, and university merchandise.
Titan Shops website

TitanCard

(Pollak Library North (PLN) 220)
The TitanCard is the university identification card used to access library and other campus services.
TitanCard website

Basic Needs Services

Basic Needs Services supports students experiencing food insecurity, housing instability, or other basic-needs challenges. Services include food assistance, hygiene products, emergency housing support, and referrals to campus and community resources.

Veterans Resource Center

Veterans Resource Center website

Computer Labs

Computer labs offer computers, printing, and commonly used software. See computer lab locations and hours.

Office of Financial Aid

(Gordon Hall 146)
Office of Financial Aid website

24. Full-Time Faculty

- **David P. Adams**, Associate Professor — Ph.D., Public Policy and Public Administration, Auburn University
- **Sean Angst**, Assistant Professor — Ph.D., Public Policy and Management, University of Southern California (Sol Price School of Public Policy)
- **Shelly Arsneault**, Professor — Ph.D., Political Science, Michigan State University
- **Clement Demoah**, Assistant Professor — Ph.D., Public Administration and Public Policy, University of Arizona (School of Government and Public Policy)
- **Meriem Doucette**, Associate Professor — Ph.D., Public Administration and Policy, University of Georgia (School of Public and International Affairs)

- **Elaine Frey**, Professor — Ph.D., Economics, George Washington University
- **Sarah A. Hill**, Professor — Ph.D., Social Science, California Institute of Technology
- **Myungjung "MJ" Kwon**, Professor — Ph.D., Public Administration and Policy, Florida State University (Askew School of Public Administration and Policy)
- **Samuel B. Stone**, Professor — Ph.D., Public Affairs, Indiana University (Paul H. O'Neill School of Public and Environmental Affairs)